

PRIVATE ALPHA GUIDE - 0.1.0-ALPHA.1

DUNGEONLORD

A practical field guide for building, raiding, surviving Councils, and keeping an endless dungeon alive.

How to use this document: This is written as a quick reference first, not a lore manual. Use the in-game First Run card for the opening raid, then return here for deeper systems.

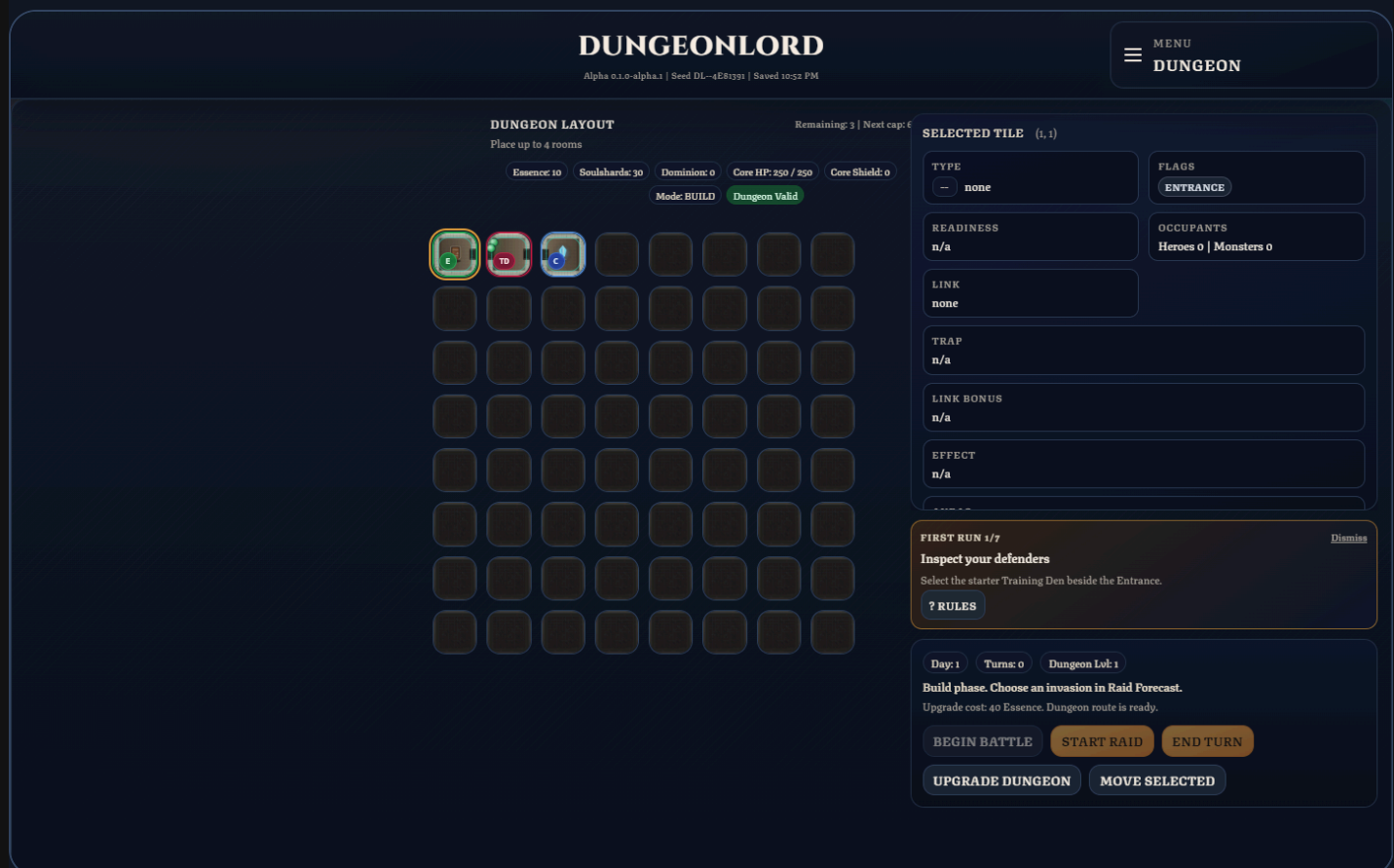
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QUICK START

Dungeonlord is an endless dungeon defense game. You build a dungeon route from the Entrance to the Core, staff monster rooms, choose invasions, survive raids, and use the rewards to expand before the next threat arrives.

First goal: Your first run begins with an Entrance, a staffed Training Den, and the Core already connected. Inspect the Training Den, choose an invasion in Raid Forecast, then begin battle.

1. Select the starter **Training Den** and confirm its monsters in Selected Tile.
2. Open **Toolbox** from the hamburger menu.
3. Pick **Normal Hero Raid** or **Elite Expedition** in Raid Forecast.
4. Use **Begin Battle**, then **Start Raid**.
5. Press **End Turn** until the raid ends.
6. Review Last Raid, spend rewards, and expand the route.



THE MAIN SCREEN

CENTER GRID

The dungeon grid is the main playfield. Rooms connect orthogonally. Utility rooms do not create walkable path.

RIGHT RAIL

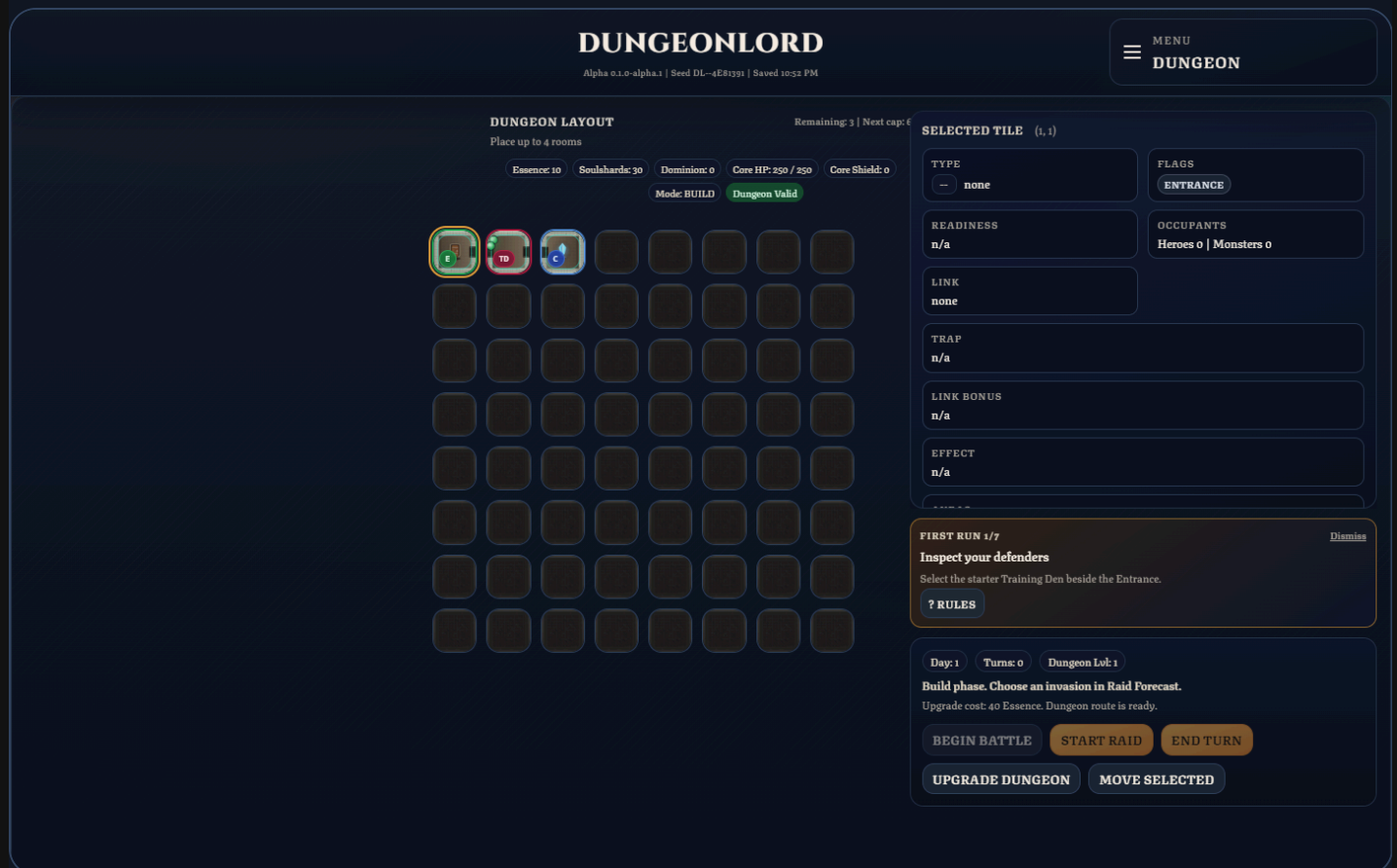
Selected Tile and run actions live here. Check it when a room, trap, monster room, or Ash Breach behaves unexpectedly.

MENU

The hamburger menu opens Toolbox, Log, Inventory, Evolution, Glossary, and Council panels.

DUNGEON HUD

Essence, Soulshards, Dominion, Core HP, Core Shield, build/battle mode, and dungeon validity appear above the grid.



BUILD PHASE

Build phase is the planning layer. You can place rooms, staff monster rooms, buy from markets, evolve monsters, move rooms, upgrade the dungeon, and choose the next invasion.

BUILD PHASE CHECKLIST

- **Valid route:** Entrance must connect to Core through path-carrying rooms.
- **Chosen invasion:** Normal or Elite must be selected unless the day forces Escalation or Council.
- **Staffed monster rooms:** Empty monster rooms do not defend themselves.
- **Armed traps:** Trap readiness shows whether a trap has charges ready for the next hero entry.

DUNGEON LEVEL AND ROOM CAP

Upgrading the dungeon increases your room cap. The current design expects a maximum dungeon level of 10, leaving unused tiles for labyrinth shape and temporary Ash Breaches.

Practical tip: Do not fill every tile just because you can. Empty space helps shape paths, makes Ash Breaches possible, and keeps the dungeon readable.

BATTLE PHASE AND RAIDS

Battle phase locks the dungeon layout and lets the invasion play out. Heroes enter, move through connected rooms, trigger traps, fight monsters, and try to damage the Core.

CORE BUTTONS

BUTTON	USE
Begin Battle	Leaves build phase after a valid invasion choice and valid dungeon route.
Start Raid	Spawns the current invading party at the active entrance.
End Turn	Advances hero movement, room combat, traps, statuses, and Core attacks.
Upgrade Dungeon	Spends Essence to increase dungeon level and room cap during build phase.
Move Selected	Starts build-phase room movement. Entrance cannot be moved.

Core damage persists: ordinary build phases do not repair the Core. Core HP is the long-term survival clock of an endless run, so even a cleared raid can leave lasting damage.

RAID TYPES

RAID	WHAT IT MEANS
Normal Hero Raid	Baseline expedition. Usually the safest choice when testing a new layout.
Elite Expedition	Smaller but stronger party with a leader trait. Higher reward and +1 Evolution on clear.
Escalation Raid	Forced every fifth non-Council day. It scales upward as you clear escalations.
Council Retaliation	Forced punishment raid from Dungeonlords, especially after repeated Council declines.

[illegible]

ROOMS

PATH-CARRYING ROOMS

Entrance, Core, trap rooms, monster rooms, and Ash Breaches count as path-carrying tiles. Heroes can move through them when connected.

TRAP ROOMS

Trap rooms trigger when heroes enter. They use charges and readiness. A trap showing **R1** or higher is ready. A trap at **R0** has spent its charges. Armed traps automatically restore their raid charges when the next build day begins.

- Traps can be armed, disarmed, and rearmed during build phase, but ordinary raid resets do not require manual toggling.
- Some artifacts and linked rooms add trap charge or damage bonuses.
- Trap kills can trigger economy effects from artifacts and support rooms.

MONSTER ROOMS

Monster rooms hold defenders. The exact hero and monster count appears in Selected Tile and Tile Details. On the grid, green radar pings indicate monsters and red pings indicate heroes in monster rooms.

- Use room staffing controls to place a chosen inventory monster.
- Use Return to Inventory or Withdraw All to free room slots.
- Training Den and similar permanent placement buffs stay with monsters after withdrawal.

UTILITY ROOMS

Utility rooms are non-walkable support rooms. They provide auras or local effects but do not connect the route.

Common mistake: If the dungeon is invalid, check whether you accidentally tried to use a utility room as part of the path.

Screenshot placeholder: selected trap room showing readiness and selected monster room showing occupant counts.

ROOM LINKS AND AURAS

Room Links and Auras are related but not the same.

ROOM LINK

A new Blood, Ward, or Hunt room is linked if it is orthogonally adjacent to another new room with the same tag.

AURA

A utility room can affect nearby rooms within its stated range even if those rooms are not linked.

EXAMPLE

Butcher's Shrine has the Blood tag. It links with adjacent Blood rooms such as **Gore Channel** or **Carnage Pit**. It does not link with **Arrow Gallery**, because Arrow Gallery is not a Blood room.

However, Butcher's Shrine can still appear in the Aura list for nearby rooms because its base utility effect affects hero deaths within 1 tile.

TAG	IDENTITY	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Blood	Kill rewards, wounded heroes, healing, Essence and Soulshards.	Gore Channel, Carnage Pit, Butcher's Shrine.
Ward	Guard, defense, Weaken, trap charge support.	Warding Sigil, Bulwark Hall, Aegis Lantern.
Hunt	Lure, speed, Marked heroes, scouting pressure.	Murder Holes, Pack Blind, Scent Beacon.

SAVING AND PLAYTEST REPORTS

Dungeonlord auto-saves in the browser and keeps one automatic backup. The Run section under Advanced Management provides manual save, export, import, backup restore, and diagnostic tools.

- **Export Save:** downloads a portable JSON file that can be moved to another browser or device.
- **Restore Backup:** restores the previous valid automatic save.
- **Copy Diagnostics:** copies build version, seed, day, phase, raid state, validation state, and recent logs.
- **Copy With Save:** includes the full save when a developer needs an exact reproduction.

When reporting a problem, include the device, browser, build version, run seed, expected result, actual result, reproduction steps, and a screenshot for visual issues.

ECONOMY

RESOURCE	MAIN USES
Essence	Build rooms, upgrade dungeon, buy some artifacts, buy or recruit monsters.
Soulshards	Buy Shady Dealer artifacts and other soul economy upgrades.
Dominion	Battle powers such as Pulse, Shield, Speed, and Strength.
Evolution	Evolve or ascend monsters into stronger forms.
Darkcrystals	Flesh Market purchases, sacrifices, fusion, and doctrine pressure.

SHADY DEALER ARTIFACTS

Standard artifacts are finite collectibles with unlock days and copy caps. When the catalog is exhausted, the dealer may have nothing new to offer.

MONSTER TRADER

The trader offers recruitable monsters based on current day unlocks. Later runs unlock deeper monster pools.



FLESH MARKET AND FUSION

The Flesh Market is opened by Council access, especially through Maltheron. It uses Darkcrystals and competes with other long-run investments.

SACRIFICE

- Only inventory monsters can be sacrificed.
- Unique monsters cannot be sacrificed.
- Sacrifice converts monsters into Darkcrystals.

FUSION

- Fusion uses exactly 2 inventory monsters.
- The primary monster determines the body and displayed base identity.
- The secondary monster contributes a trait, passive, and stat bias.
- Unique and already fused monsters are not valid ingredients in the current version.
- The result is a fused Abomination-style monster with inherited star, stage, and up to 2 passives.

Screenshot placeholder: Flesh Market and Fusion Crucible preview before confirming fusion.

COUNCIL OF THE DUNGEONLORDS

Every tenth day is a Council day. Council days interrupt the normal invasion cadence. You can attend, decline, accept boons, accept quests, and manage relationships.

FAVOR

ACTION	FAVOR EFFECT
Attend Council	+1 with each attendee.
Decline Council	-1 with each attendee.
Accept boon	+2 with that sponsor.
Accept quest	+1 with that sponsor.
Complete quest	+2 with that sponsor.
Fail or expire quest	-2 with that sponsor.

Favor drifts 1 step toward neutral whenever a new Council convenes. Rivalries cause a 1 point opposite shift with rival Dungeonlords.

FAVOR BANDS

BAND	ACCESS
Hostile	Boons and quests locked.
Wary	Boons available, quests locked.
Neutral	Boons and standard quests available.
Favored	Boons, standard quests, and hard quests available.
Allied	Full access, plus improved banded rewards when applicable.

Screenshot placeholder: Council chamber with selected Dungeonlord and favor band visible.

NIHAZA AND ASH BREACHES

Matriarch Nihaza introduces temporary structural pressure. Her trial opens Ash Breaches on valid edge tiles near combat frontage.

ASH TRIAL RULES

- Standard trial opens 1 Ash Breach.
- Hard trial opens 2 Ash Breaches.
- Every active entrance must stay connected to the Core.
- Complete the required raids before the next Council to succeed.
- Breaches collapse on success or failure.

Important: Ash Breaches are temporary entrances. If one is disconnected from the Core, the dungeon becomes invalid until you reconnect it or the trial collapses.

Screenshot placeholder: Ash Breach connected to the main dungeon route.

DOMINION AND EMERGENCY TOOLS

Dominion powers are battle tools. They are strongest when used to prevent a raid from snowballing into Core damage.

POWER	USE CASE
Pulse	Damages all heroes before they act. Best when several weakened heroes are alive.
Shield	Adds Core Shield. Best when heroes are close to the Core.
Speed	Monsters act first this turn. Best in crowded monster rooms.
Strength	Monsters gain ATK this turn. Best when defenders are already fighting.

EVOLUTION

Monsters can evolve when they have enough personal and/or global Evolution points. Evolution improves stats and can alter combat identity.

- Elite and Escalation clears can grant bonus Evolution.
- Some Council sponsors reward Evolution directly.
- Do not hoard Evolution too long if a key defender is falling behind.

COMMON PROBLEMS

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
Begin Battle is disabled.	No invasion selected, invalid route, or Council not resolved.	Check Raid Forecast, dungeon validity, and Council state.
Dungeon is invalid.	Core is disconnected, utility room is breaking path, or Ash Breach is disconnected.	Use path preview and connect every entrance to Core.
A support room says unlinked.	It is not adjacent to a same-tag Blood/Ward/Hunt room.	Place a matching tag room orthogonally adjacent.
A room shows an aura but no link.	Auras and links are separate systems.	Read Selected Tile: Aura means nearby influence; Link means same-tag adjacency.
Heroes reach Core too easily.	Route is too short or monster rooms are understaffed.	Add detours, trap chains, and staffed monster rooms before the Core.
Long run has no dealer stock.	You may have capped all eligible standard artifacts.	Advance to later unlock days or wait for future catalog updates.

FIRST RUN BUILD ADVICE

SIMPLE SAFE ROUTE

1. Place one trap room between Entrance and Core.
2. Place one monster room after the trap.
3. Staff the monster room before battle.
4. Choose Normal Hero Raid for the first fight.
5. Use rewards to add a utility room near the combat cluster.

WHEN TO PICK ELITE

Pick Elite when your route has at least one reliable trap, a staffed monster room, and enough Core HP or Core Shield to absorb mistakes. Elite rewards are better, but early elite leaders can punish weak layouts.

WHEN TO UPGRADE DUNGEON

Upgrade when you are close to room cap and your next build plan needs more tiles. Upgrading before you know what you want can waste Essence that might have bought monsters, artifacts, or traps.

Screenshot placeholder: example beginner route with labels for trap, monster room, support room, and Core.

SCREENSHOT REPLACEMENT NOTES

This PDF was generated from `docs/Dungeonlord_Guidebook.html`. To add images later, edit the HTML source and replace a screenshot placeholder block with an image tag.

Example:

```

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Recommended image workflow: place screenshots in `docs/assets/`, update the HTML, then run `node scripts/render-guidebook.mjs`.